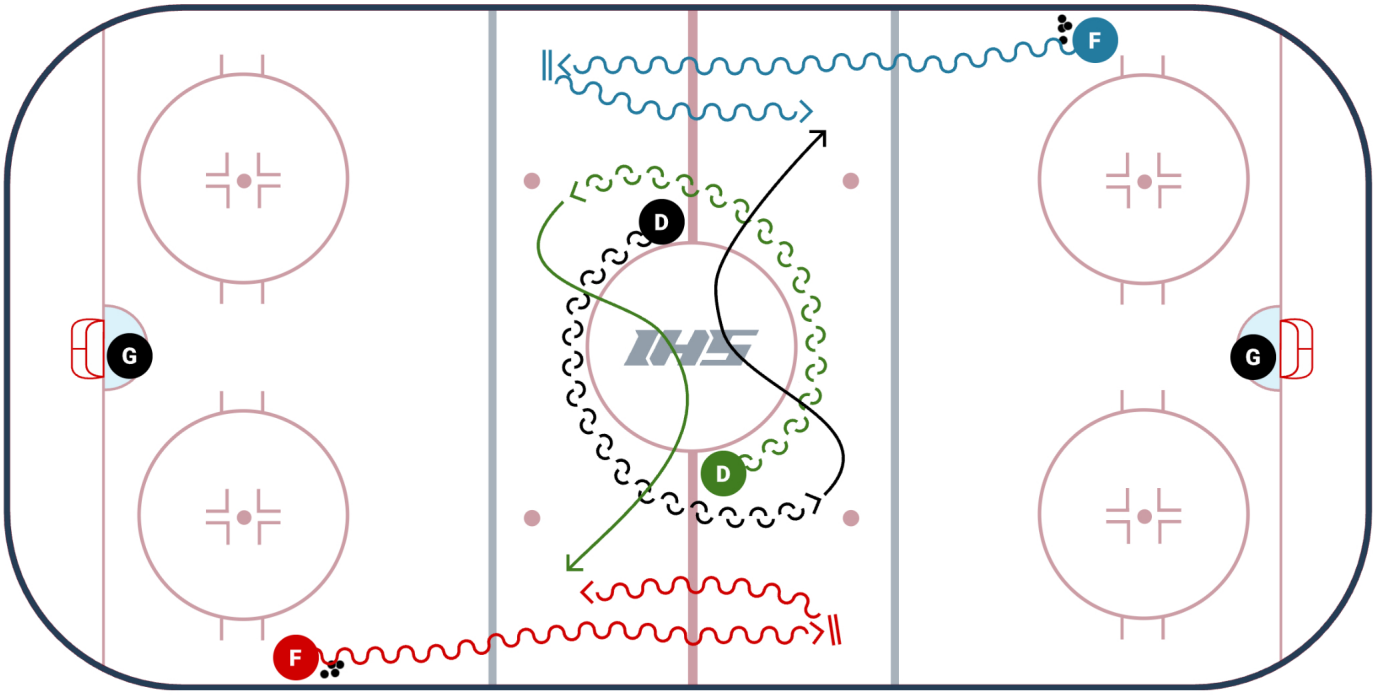
1 ON 1 RE-GAP TRANSITION



Time: **Station:**



The 1-on-1 Re-gap Transition Drill from Michael Peca was recorded during the 2024-25 NHL Season. It is designed to teach players how to defend effectively by transitioning quickly from backward to forward skating, closing gaps, angling, and forcing turnovers before the defensive blue line. This drill applies to all positions, as players often find themselves needing to defend in transition situations throughout a game.

Setup:

- **Starting Positions:**
  - Two players begin just off the top of the circle, each with a puck.
  - Two defensive players start by skating backward in the neutral zone, around the center ice faceoff circle.
  - The coach is positioned at center ice with a whistle to trigger transitions.
- **Initial Movement:**
  - On the first whistle, both defensive players start backpedaling with quick crossovers into the neutral zone, while the offensive players skate up ice.

Execution:

- **Transition at the Whistle:**
  - The coach blows the whistle, signaling an immediate stop and change of direction.
  - The player in the defensive role pivots from backward to forward skating, transitioning into a gap-up position against the offensive player on the other side of the ice.
- **Closing the Gap:**
  - The defensive player must quickly close space and angle the offensive player toward the boards.
  - The goal is to force a turnover before reaching the defensive blue line.

- **Unpredictable Attack Path:**
  - Unlike standard angle drills, this drill requires reactive defending based on the speed and positioning of the offensive player.
  - Faster offensive players may force the play to the blue line or beyond, challenging the defender's ability to adjust gap control dynamically.
- **Defensive Priorities:**
  - **Stick on Puck:**
    - The defender must establish stick-on-puck first before engaging physically.
    - When the defender's stick is active, it often causes the offensive player to slow down or hesitate.
  - **Body Positioning:**
    - Once stick pressure is applied, defenders close with their body to eliminate time and space.
  - **Gap Control:**
    - The defender should challenge themselves to establish an early gap, even at the risk of getting beat, to develop a better feel for neutral zone defense.

Key Teaching Points:

- **Quick Transition:** Teach players to react instantly from backward to forward skating to establish a defensive gap.
- **Closing Space:** Defenders must angle properly and gap up aggressively before the blue line.
- **Stick on Puck First:** Proper defensive technique involves disrupting the puck first before engaging with the body.
- **Unpredictability in Defense:** Defenders must react to the offensive player's depth and speed instead of relying on set patterns.

Variations:

- Adjust the starting depth to increase or decrease difficulty.
- Allow offensive players to use deceptive maneuvers to test the defender's reactions.